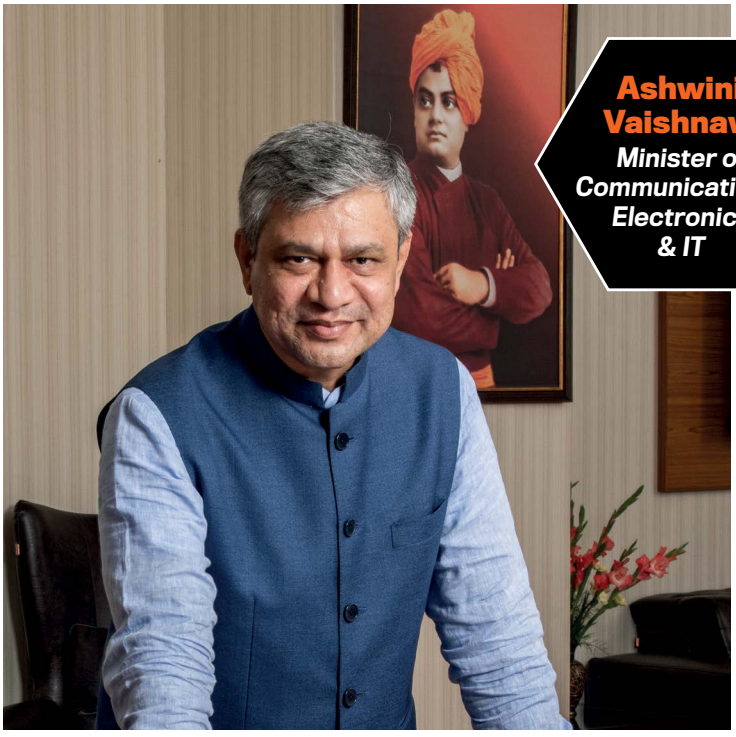
Wiring Up the Nation

Speedy building of infrastructure and a push for indigenous production of telecom equipment have remained a key thrust

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



Ashwini Vaishnaw
Minister of Communications; Electronics & IT

BANDEEP SINGH

ON MAY 24, UNION minister of electronics and information technology (MeitY) and communications Ashwini Vaishnaw inaugurated India's 200,000th 5G site in Dehradun and predicted that by the end of 2023, 100,000 more sites would be added.

When he took over as the communications and MeitY minister in July 2021, Vaishnaw faced policy bottlenecks. PM Modi had tasked him to build infrastructure, while keeping self-reliance in focus. Vaishnaw faced opposition from the RSS-affiliated Swadeshi Jagran Manch and Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh for pushing for the disinvestment of BSNL. He has abandoned the plan, and is instead using the PSU to push for domestic manufacturing. State-owned telecom R&D firm C-DoT has partnered with a TCS-led consortium for a deal with BSNL to deploy a 4G network across India. BSNL will use a 4G Core developed by C-DoT. Not just this, C-DoT has developed a 5G Non-Standalone (NSA) Core, which establishes reliable, secure connectivity. India has over 759 million active internet users, and it is estimated that 56 per cent of all new users in India by 2025 will be from rural areas. This justifies the MeitY's focus on indigenous production of telecom equipment. Vaishnaw—himself a communications and electronics engineer—has actively led this push. In March 2023, he came out with India's 6G roadmap, the vision document Bharat 6G and opened the 6G R&D test bed. The minister has anchored two of the biggest PLI (production-linked incentive) schemes to support telecom and IT development. ■

BOLD & BRAVE

50
No. of Indian cities with 5G

56%
Estimated share of rural users among new internet users by 2025

200,000
No. of 5G sites in India

BUT...

Data Privacy Bill has yet to be passed

